How Young People's Feelings about the Future Affect their Democratic Attitudes and Political Participation

<Participant instructions> On the next page, you'll see an Instagram post. We're interested in how people engage with social media, so **please take a good look at the post and comments** before answering the questions about the post.
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<Randomly display one of the three Instagram posts to participants>

<Condition 1: Anxiety>

<Condition 2: Hope>

<Condition 3: Control>

<Questions displayed directly below on the same page as the Instagram post>

W2_exp_comment: If you would leave a comment on the post, what would you write?
<Open ended response>

W2_exp_reaction: If you could react with an emoji to the post, which one would you choose?
<non-randomised horizontal display>

1. 😡
2. 😰
3. 😌
4. 😊
5. 😄

W2_exp_share: How likely would you be to share the post with your friends?

1. Very unlikely
2. Unlikely
3. Neither likely nor unlikely
4. Likely
5. Very likely

W2_exp_like: How likely would you leave a 'like' on the post?

1. Very unlikely
2. Unlikely
3. Neither likely nor unlikely
4. Likely
5. Very likely

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Democratic support

W2_exp_demX: When you think about the political system that is best for the future of the UK, to what extent do you agree with the following statements?

- **W2_exp_dem1:** The government should be able to censor media sources that are too critical
- **W2_exp_dem2:** This country would be better off if there were only one political party
- **W2_exp_dem3:** The universal right to vote must be questioned when so many voters are poorly informed and easily misled
- **W2_exp_dem4:** We should respect the results of elections, no matter which party wins
- **W2_exp_dem5:** The government should be able to ignore court rulings that are regarded as politically biased
- **W2_exp_dem6:** If the UK parliament hinders the work of the government, it should be ignored
- **W2_exp_dem7:** The government should be able to bend the law to solve pressing social and political problems
- **W2_exp_dem8:** Help us keep track of who is paying attention. Please choose the response option 'Disagree' as answer for this question

1. Strongly disagree
2. Disagree
3. Neither agree nor disagree
4. Agree
5. Strongly agree

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Conjoint political candidate choice with 4 rounds

<On each round two leaders with five attributes and several levels per attribute are displayed. Levels are randomly assigned based on the probabilities displayed in brackets in the table below. Each leader is assigned one level for each attribute>

Attribute	**Levels (Probabilities)**
Gender	Male (0.5), Female (0.5)
Age	30-69 (random)
Political Party	Conservatives (0.29), Labour (0.29), Reform UK (0.14), Liberal Democrats (0.14), Green Party (0.14)
Recent behaviour:	Said it is legitimate to fight political opponents in the streets if one feels provoked / Said it is unacceptable to fight political opponents in the streets even though one feels provoked (0.125/0.125) Supported a proposal to reduce polling stations in areas that support opposing parties / Supported a proposal to preserve existing polling-stations in all areas (0.125/0.125) Said court rulings by judges appointed by opposing parties should be ignored / adhered to (0.125/0.125) Said it is acceptable to harass journalists that do not reveal sources / Said it is unacceptable to harass journalists even though they do not reveal sources (0.125/0.125)
Reputation	Good / Bad at handling economic matters (0.333/0.333), Neither good nor bad reputation on economic matters (0.333)

W2_exp_conjointX: Which candidate would you prefer as prime minister?

1. Candidate A
2. Candidate B

<Screenshot of example round 1>

<Participant information on each choice trial> Imagine that the following two candidates run for the 2029 General Election:

Imagine that the following two candidates run for the 2029 General Election:

	Candidate A	**Candidate B**
Sex	Male	Male
Age	60	54
Political party	Reform UK	Green Party
Recent behaviour	Said it is acceptable to harass journalists that do not reveal sources	Supported a proposal to reduce polling stations in areas that support opposing parties
Reputation	Neither good nor bad reputation on economic matters	Good at handling economic matters

Which candidate would you prefer as prime minister?

Candidate A	Candidate B

Political participation

W2_exp_polpartX: Listed below are different ways on how you can take part in political life. Thinking about the coming years, how likely is it that you would do the following:

- **W2_exp_polpart1**: Explain to friends or family why it's important to vote in a national or local election
- **W2_exp_polpart2**: Share a political post in your story on social media (e.g., Instagram, Snapchat)
- **W2_exp_polpart3**: Send a political TikTok / Reel / Short to a friend on your social media
- **W2_exp_polpart4**: Discuss political topics with others online, such as in comments sections or group chats
- **W2_exp_polpart5**: Participate in a legal protest, march, or demonstration about an issue you care about

1. Very unlikely
2. Unlikely
3. Neither likely nor unlikely
4. Likely
5. Very likely

Political information-seeking

W2_exp_polinfo: This part of the survey is completely optional: We have collected information about ways to get more involved in democracy in the UK. Would you like to view these resources?

[ ] Yes, I want to see information on how to get more involved in democracy
[ ] No, I do not want to see information on how to get more involved in democracy

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Five ways to have your say

Democracy is about having your say and getting involved all year round. Whether that's through exercising your freedom of speech, getting involved in your local community volunteering, starting or signing a petition, protesting, campaigning, joining a youth parliament, lobbying, contacting your elected representative, finding ways large and small to take part in Civic and Civil Society.

1. Protest, Campaign and Organise
Join with others to amplify your voice. Freedom to assemble (getting together with others in public) is your right. Know your rights. Get a copy of The Young Citizen's Passport – a guide to those parts of the law most relevant to the everyday life of young people in England and Wales.

2. Join a School Council, Youth Parliament or stand for public office
In primary and/or secondary school and/or a Youth Parliament from age 11-18 and when you are 18 or over stand for public office. Yes you!!! Become a Councillor or even stand to be elected as a member of a devolved parliament or the UK parliament.

3. Start a petition
Start a petition and get it debated by the UK Parliament, or a Devolved Parliament (if you live in Scotland, Wales or NI).

4. Register to Vote
Register to vote:

- at 14 if you live in Wales and Scotland
- or 16 if you live in England
- or 17 if you live in Northern Ireland

5. Vote
Check out The Electoral Commission for trusted and unbiased public information about your vote and all elections.

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Manipulation & attention check

W2_exp_check: Thinking back to the Instagram post that you saw earlier, to what extent did the post make you feel …
<randomised slider display>
Anxious 0 (Not at all) - 100 (Very much)
Angry 0 (Not at all) - 100 (Very much)
Hopeful 0 (Not at all) - 100 (Very much)
Happy 0 (Not at all) - 100 (Very much)
Calm 0 (Not at all) - 100 (Very much)

W2_exp_attention: And what was the main topic of the Instagram post that you saw earlier?

1. Immigration policy
2. Costs of living
3. English education
4. Voter registration
5. The US election

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Debriefing

Thank you for participating in this study! We want to provide you with some information about the **Instagram post** you saw earlier.

- **The post was created for this research study.** While the information about the cost of living and inflation in the UK was accurate and taken from reliable sources, the Instagram post itself was made specifically for this study.
- **The comments and the source were not real.** The comments on the post were fictional, and the source ("UKDAILYDIGEST") does not exist.
- **We aimed to evoke emotions.** Research in affective psychology shows that seeing emotional content can influence how people feel. We showed you this post to understand how different emotions about the future, like anxiety or hope, might affect your views on democracy.

Please confirm your understanding:

[ ] I understand that the Instagram post I saw was created for this research study and that some elements were not real.